Say it to your boss.

An ambitious goal can excite you and unsettle you at the same time. This dossier gives you the research, the sentences and the grammar to have the conversation with your boss before the goal becomes a problem.

NAME _____ DATE _____

This is your page for the lesson. The numbers and titles match the lesson on the screen. Write on the lines, circle your answer. **Bold on grey** is a chunk to learn. Dotted is a word to look up. The Portuguese for these words is on the last pages.

1 WARM UP

Where do you stand?

Before you read anything, tell us what you think. Circle the answer closest to your opinion. There is no right answer.

My boss usually explains why a goal matters.

○ Strongly disagree ○ Disagree ○ Not sure ○ Agree ○ Strongly agree

I would feel comfortable saying "this deadline is unrealistic."

○ Strongly disagree ○ Disagree ○ Not sure ○ Agree ○ Strongly agree

I work best when a goal makes me slightly uncomfortable.

○ Strongly disagree ○ Disagree ○ Not sure ○ Agree ○ Strongly agree

A measurable target motivates me more than "do your best."

○ Strongly disagree ○ Disagree ○ Not sure ○ Agree ○ Strongly agree

I tell my boss about a risk before it becomes a problem.

○ Strongly disagree ○ Disagree ○ Not sure ○ Agree ○ Strongly agree

I often keep my concerns to myself to avoid friction.

○ Strongly disagree ○ Disagree ○ Not sure ○ Agree ○ Strongly agree

How do goals usually reach you?

Think about your job. If you do not work, think about school or a course.

○ In a meeting, with the reasoning explained.
○ In writing, with a number and a date.
○ As a vague direction, like "do your best."
○ I set my own goals.

Two numbers about you

Write your number, then compare it with a partner.

How clear are the goals you work towards?

Move the slider. 0 is not clear at all. 100 is completely clear.

My number _____ / 100

How easy is it to push back on your boss, a teacher or a coach?

Move the slider. 0 is very hard. 100 is very easy.

My number _____ / 100

Talk about these first

Then read the article and see who agrees with you.

1 Think of a goal that felt **out of reach** at first. Who set it, and how was it communicated?

---

2 Which channel do you trust most when you receive a goal: a meeting, an email or a quick message? Why?

---

3 When did you stay quiet and **regret** it later? What were you afraid of?

---

4 What is one sentence you would like to say to your boss, but have never said? What stops you?

---

5 What can a boss do to make it easier for people to speak up?

---

2 ARTICLE

WORK · BOSSES

Four sentences that change the conversation with your boss

Most of us nod in meetings and worry afterwards. Four sentences can change that, and the research explains why they work.

By EIC Magazine · 4 min read

Most of us have nodded along to a goal we found **daunting**, said "sounds good," and **brooded** about it for a week. Silence feels safe, but it rarely is.

In 1980, John Gabarro and John Kotter argued in Harvard Business Review that managing your boss is part of your job. You and your boss depend on each other, and the **burden** of finding out what your boss expects falls on you. The four sentences below put that idea into practice.

ASK FOR CLARITY

A boss who says "just do your best" has not told you what success looks like, and the gap will be filled with guesses. Gabarro and Kotter describe effective employees as people who test their assumptions by questioning the boss and others around them. Try this: "What does success look like here, and how will we measure it?"

SAY IT EARLY

Bosses often give off signals that they only want good news, but a superior needs to hear about failures as well as successes. Gabarro and Kotter also warn that an optimistic delivery date may please your boss in the short term and become a source of displeasure if it is not honored. One president quoted in the article would take a more consistent employee over one with a few **peak** successes. If a goal is slipping, say so while there is still time to adjust. Try this: "I see a risk, and I would rather you heard it from me today."

DISAGREE WITHOUT DAMAGE

Why do so many capable people stay quiet? In a 2011 paper, Jim Detert and Amy Edmondson described "implicit voice theories": **taken-for-granted** rules that people use to decide whether speaking up is safe or worthwhile, often without realizing it. Because these rules operate below the surface, they are rarely tested. A practical way to test one is to begin with **common ground**: "I am fully behind the goal. My concern is the date. Would it be possible to move it by a week?"

ASK FOR WHAT YOU NEED

Ambitious goals need resources: time, people, information. Name what you need and why it matters: "To do this well, I would need two things." Remember, though, Gabarro and Kotter's reminder that your boss's time, energy and influence are limited, and every request uses some of them. Make fewer, better requests.

Before your next meeting, choose one sentence and say it aloud, twice. The first attempt will feel **clumsy**. The second rarely does.

"I am fully behind the goal. My concern is the date. Would it be possible to move it by a week?"

A sentence for this lesson

1980
the year Gabarro and Kotter published "Managing Your Boss" in Harvard Business Review

4 studies
in Detert and Edmondson's 2011 research on why people stay quiet at work

5 kinds
of unspoken rules about speaking up, measured in those studies

180 teams
studied by Google: psychological safety came first of five dynamics

Sources: Gabarro and Kotter, Managing Your Boss, Harvard Business Review (1980; reprinted 2005); Detert and Edmondson, Implicit Voice Theories: Taken-for-Granted Rules of Self-Censorship at Work, Academy of Management Journal (2011); Google re:Work, Understand team effectiveness. The sentences to say are written for this lesson.

Comments

6 readers · fictional voices for this lesson

Camila R. · Campinas · customer support
My manager kept saying "give it your best shot." I finally asked, "What does success look like, in numbers?" It turned out she wanted 450 **tickets** a month, not 600.

Rafael · Recife · developer
I gave my manager **a heads-up** about the delay on Monday instead of hoping to make up for it it by Friday. She was not thrilled, but she appreciated it, and we re-scoped the work in a day.

Dona Lúcia · Curitiba · retired nurse
In my day, nobody questioned the head nurse. I wish someone had taught me one polite way to push back.

Tiago · Porto Alegre · sales
I disagree in private, never in the meeting. My boss tends to take it personally when he is corrected in front of the team, so I save my objections for the **one-to-one**.

Júlia · Lisbon · designer
I asked for extra **headcount**. He said no, but he cleared my calendar for two weeks, which turned out to be the real **bottleneck**.

Marcos · Belo Horizonte · **intern**
I am new, so I stay quiet. Everyone else does, and I assume they know something I do not.

Words from the article

Hover on the screen, or look here.

a heads-up
um aviso antecipado

below the surface
por baixo da superfície, escondido

bottleneck
gargalo

brood
remoer, ficar ruminando

burden
responsabilidade pesada, ônus

clumsy
desajeitado

common ground
pontos em comum

daunting
intimidador, assustador

depend on
depender de

headcount
número de pessoas na equipe, vaga aprovada

in private
em particular

intern
estagiário

make up for
compensar

matter
importar

nod along
concordar com a cabeça só por concordar

one-to-one
reunião individual

peak
de pico, máximo

push back
se opor, resistir (com educação)

re-scope
redefinir o escopo

slip
escorregar, atrasar aos poucos

take it personally
levar para o lado pessoal

taken for granted
tido como certo, sem questionar

test your assumptions
testar as próprias suposições

ticket
chamado, solicitação de atendimento

More words from the exercises

The same chunks and phrases, from sections 3 to 8.

adjust
ajustar

average
média

conditions
condições, situação atual

customer support
suporte ao cliente

defend
defender

estimate
estimativa

flag
sinalizar, alertar

frankly
francamente

keep your pace
manter o ritmo

leave
sair da empresa

out of reach
fora de alcance

quarter
trimestre

regret
se arrepender

run something by
consultar alguém sobre algo

start at
começar em (um número)

sweet spot
ponto ideal, faixa ideal

timeline
cronograma, prazo

track record
histórico de resultados

unrealistic
irreal, inviável

untested
não testado

What does success look like?
como é o sucesso? (como saberemos que a meta foi atingida?)

3 CHECK

What does the article say?

Facts first, then voices. Every answer is in the text or in the comments.

True or false?

Read the sentence. Is it true, according to the article? If it is false, write the correct fact on the line.

EXAMPLE "The article says you should wait for your boss to explain exactly what is expected."

False
It is false. The article says the burden falls on you to find out what your boss expects.

1 "Gabarro and Kotter suggest that the employee, not the boss, should take the initiative to find out what the boss expects."

◯ True ◯ False

If false, write the correct fact.

---

2 "According to the article, an optimistic delivery date is a reliable way to earn your boss's trust."

◯ True ◯ False

If false, write the correct fact.

---

3 "The article says that people apply "implicit voice theories" deliberately, after weighing the risks."

◯ True ◯ False

If false, write the correct fact.

---

4 "The article recommends beginning a disagreement with what you support."

◯ True ◯ False

If false, write the correct fact.

---

5 "A president quoted in the article prefers a consistent employee to one with a few peak successes."

◯ True ◯ False

If false, write the correct fact.

---

6 "Gabarro and Kotter advise you to make as many requests as possible, because bosses expect them."

◯ True ◯ False

If false, write the correct fact.

Find the reader

All the answers are in the comments, below the article. Read between the lines: the comments do not use the same words as the questions.

EXAMPLE Who wishes someone had taught her one polite way to disagree with a superior?

Dona Lúcia

Dona Lúcia: "I wish someone had taught me one polite way to push back."

1 Who found that a bad-news message was received better than he or she feared?

◯ Tiago ◯ Rafael ◯ Marcos

2 Who protects the boss from being corrected in public?

◯ Tiago ◯ Camila ◯ Júlia

3 Who discovered that the real obstacle was not the resource he or she asked for?

◯ Rafael ◯ Dona Lúcia ◯ Júlia

4 Who stays quiet because of an assumption about what the others know?

◯ Marcos ◯ Camila ◯ Tiago

4 FEARS

Why we stay quiet

Why do capable people stay quiet? Detert and Edmondson found that people carry unspoken rules about speaking up, apply them without thinking, and rarely test them. The six fears below are common examples written for this lesson. They are not a list from the paper.

Four fears

1. **My boss will take it personally.**
2. **It will cost me later.**
3. **I will look incompetent.**
4. **I will be the only one.**
5. **I do not have enough proof.**
6. **I will be seen as negative.**

Which fear is it?

Read what each person thinks. Circle the fear behind the thought. Look for the exact worry, not the general topic.

EXAMPLE Paulo thinks: "If I turn down this project, my name will not come up when the next big one is assigned."

It will cost me later.

His worry is about the consequences, later in his career. The fear is not about the boss's feelings.

1 Ana thinks: "She designed this plan herself. If I say the timeline is unrealistic, she will hear it as an attack on her."

- ○ I will be seen as negative.
- ○ My boss will take it personally.
- ○ I will look incompetent.

2 Bruno thinks: "I have a feeling the forecast is wrong, but I cannot show it yet. If I raise it now, they will ask for numbers I do not have."

- ○ I will be the only one.
- ○ I will look incompetent.
- ○ I do not have enough proof.

3 Carla thinks: "Everyone seems to understand the new system. If I admit I am lost, they will wonder how I got this job."

- ○ I will be seen as negative.
- ○ I will look incompetent.
- ○ It will cost me later.

4 Diego thinks: "Nobody has raised a concern in three meetings. If I go first, I will be the one who made it awkward."

- ○ I will be the only one.
- ○ My boss will take it personally.
- ○ I do not have enough proof.

5 Elisa thinks: “Every time I point out a problem, I can feel the mood drop. I do not want to become the person who always brings bad news.”

- ◯ I will be seen as negative.
- ◯ It will cost me later.
- ◯ I will be the only one.

6 Fábio thinks: “My review is next month. If I challenge him now, it will be in the back of his mind when he scores me.”

- ◯ My boss will take it personally.
- ◯ I will look incompetent.
- ◯ It will cost me later.

Has this fear ever really come true for you? Many people never test their fear.

YOUR TURN · YOUR FEAR

Think of a time you held back in front of a boss, a teacher or a coach. Which fear was it? Did it come true? What would you say now?

5 CHUNKS

Chunks and patterns

The four things to say use the same phrases again and again. Learn the whole phrase and the pattern that goes with it, and the sentence builds itself.

Three families you already know

The four sentences use verb patterns. The first verb decides what comes next. These are the same Families 1, 2 and 3 from the Verb Patterns lesson, with the more formal verbs you need at work.

FAMILY	THE PATTERN	THE VERBS	EXAMPLE
1	**verb + person + to + verb**	ask · expect · urge · encourage · advise · would appreciate · get	“I would urge you to reconsider the date.”
2	**let · make · have + person + verb**	Only three verbs. No to after the person. Get is different: get + person + to + verb.	“Would you let me set my own priorities?”
3	**suggest · recommend · propose · insist + that + person + verb**	Formal. The verb stays in the base form: that we move, that she join.	“I propose that we set the goal at 520.”

Where the not goes

FAMILY	WHERE THE NOT GOES	EXAMPLE
1	**Two places**	“I didn’t ask them to start.” × “I asked them not to start.”
2	**The first verb**	“I didn’t let them start.” Never “I let them not start.”
3	**After that**	“I suggest that they not start.” Never “that they don’t start.”

Pick the chunk

Circle the words that complete the sentence. Each answer is a chunk or a pattern, not a single word.

EXAMPLE My manager expects the team _____ the report by Friday.

to submit

Family 1: expect + person + to + verb.

1 I would urge you _____ the date before we commit.

○ to reconsider ○ reconsidering ○ reconsider

2 The numbers made me _____ whether the goal was realistic.

○ wondering ○ to wonder ○ wonder

3 I would appreciate it if you _____ me know sooner.

○ will to let ○ could let ○ would to let

4 She insisted that the report _____ before the meeting.

○ be sent ○ was sent ○ to be sent

5 I advised my team not _____ any date until we had the data.

○ promising ○ promise ○ to promise

6 My boss let me _____ my own timeline.

○ set ○ setting ○ to set

7 It is essential that every request _____ a clear reason.

○ has ○ have ○ to have

8 Rafael got his manager _____ to a smaller scope.

○ to agree ○ agreeing ○ agree

9 I raised the risk early, which allowed us _____ the plan.

○ adjusting ○ adjust ○ to adjust

10 I would rather you _____ it from me than from the client.

○ hear ○ heard ○ to hear

Write the missing word

Write the missing word or words in the space. Use the pattern from the lesson. The verb in brackets is the one you need.

EXAMPLE My manager made us **rewrite** the plan twice. (rewrite)

Make + person + verb, with no to. The verb stays in the base form.

1 I would encourage you _____ share the risk early.

2 Her boss didn't let her _____ the date. (change)

3 I propose that he _____ the client today. (call)

4 We asked the team not _____ extra work without approval.

5 A good boss gets people _____ openly. (talk)

6 She insisted that they _____ the data first. (check)

7 I would prefer that we not _____ the date yet. (set)

8 He made me _____ what I really meant. (explain)

Where does the not go?

Read the situation. Circle the sentence that says it.

EXAMPLE You never asked Ana to stay late. She stayed because she wanted to.

I didn't ask Ana to stay late.

You made no request, so the not goes to the first verb: didn't ask.

1 You told your team: "Do not start without approval."

- ○ I told my team don't start without approval.
- ○ I told my team not to start without approval.
- ○ I didn't tell my team to start without approval.

2 Nobody asked Lena to cover Friday. She volunteered.

- ○ I asked Lena not to cover Friday.
- ○ I didn't ask Lena covering Friday.
- ○ I didn't ask Lena to cover Friday.

3 Your boss refused to allow remote work on Fridays.

- ○ My boss didn't let us work remotely on Fridays.
- ○ My boss didn't let us to work remotely on Fridays.
- ○ My boss let us not work remotely on Fridays.

4 In an email you recommend: nobody schedules meetings on Fridays.

- ○ I recommend that nobody schedule meetings on Fridays.
- ○ I recommend nobody to schedule meetings on Fridays.
- ○ I recommend that nobody schedules meetings on Fridays.

5 You never persuaded your colleague to join the call. He came alone.

- ○ I didn't get him join the call.
- ○ I didn't get him to join the call.
- ○ I got him not to join the call.

6 Your manager insisted: nobody may share the data.

- ○ She insisted that nobody shares the data.
- ○ She insisted nobody to share the data.
- ○ She insisted that nobody share the data.

6 LISTEN

The sentence you will say tomorrow

Three short moments between an employee and a boss. Open the lesson on the screen, go to section 6 and press play. The numbers match.

What did you hear?

Listen as many times as you like. Then circle your answer.

EXAMPLE **You hear:** "Thanks for flagging this early. I would rather hear about a delay on Monday than discover it on Friday. Let's meet tomorrow at ten, and bring two options for the new date."
What does the manager ask the employee to bring?

Two options

Listen for the last sentence.

1 ▶ What two options does the employee offer?

- ○ Extend the date, or lower the number
- ○ Add a person, or extend the date
- ○ Lower the number, or cancel the project

2 ▶ What does the boss offer?

○ A smaller number of tickets ○ A later review, and freedom to choose priorities ○ A new hire in December

3 ▶ What does the employee want to know?

○ Whether the goal can be lowered ○ When the quarter starts
○ Whether 600 is monthly or for the whole quarter

7 BOSS?

Can you say it at a meeting?

Read each sentence an employee might say to a boss. Circle the blue thumb if you can say it at a meeting. Circle the pink thumb if it is too much.

		I CAN SAY IT AT A MEETING	TOO MUCH
1	"**Frankly**, this target is **unrealistic** and everyone knows it."		
2	"I fully support the goal. My concern is the **timeline**."		
3	"I told you this would happen."		
4	"With respect, you are not listening."		
5	"Fine. I will just do it, but do not blame me when it fails."		
6	"Could I run something by you before we commit?"		
7	"I would ask you to reconsider the date, and here is why."		
8	"I am flagging this early so that we can still **adjust** the plan."		
9	"That is not my job."		
10	"I am not sure I follow. Could you give me an example of what good looks like?"		

8 THE CASE

Marina sets her goal

Marina works in **customer support**. Her boss wants a big goal for the next **quarter**. Study her **track record** and her **conditions**, then choose a goal that she can **defend**. The numbers are invented for this lesson. They are not real data.

1 ASK FOR CLARITY

What does success look like here? Is 600 a target for every month, or for the quarter as a whole?

Ask before you guess. Make the goal measurable.

2 SAY IT EARLY

I see a risk, and I would rather you heard it from me today: one person leaves in November, so we will be four, not five.

Say it today, with a fact.

3 DISAGREE CALMLY

I am fully behind the goal. My concern is the number. Would it be possible to start at 520?

Common ground first. Then one concern and one option.

4 ASK FOR WHAT YOU NEED

I would need two weeks to learn the new tool. I would appreciate it if you could let me know whether it changes the plan.

Name what you need, and why.

Marina's track record

MONTH	TICKETS HANDLED
April	405
May	430
June	440
July	425
August	445
September	435

Her **average** is about 430 tickets a month, with a team of five.

Her conditions now

One person **leaves** in November. The team goes from five people to four.

A new tool arrives in December. It is **untested**, but the vendor says it could add about 10% to each person's output. Nobody knows if that is true.

Try three goals

Without the tool, Marina can **keep her pace** with four people and handle about 344 tickets a month (430 × 4 ÷ 5). If the vendor is right, the tool adds 10%, and she handles about 378. The score is the likely result divided by the goal. Google says 60 to 70 percent is the **sweet spot** for an ambitious goal.

Without the tool

THE GOAL	LIKELY RESULT	SCORE (LIKELY ÷ GOAL)	IN THE SWEET SPOT?
600	344	_____ %	○ Yes ○ No
520	344	_____ %	○ Yes ○ No
480	344	_____ %	○ Yes ○ No

With the tool

THE GOAL	LIKELY RESULT	SCORE (LIKELY ÷ GOAL)	IN THE SWEET SPOT?
600	378	_____ %	○ Yes ○ No
520	378	_____ %	○ Yes ○ No

480	378	_____ %	○ Yes	○ No

This is a simple **estimate** for the lesson, with invented data. A real plan needs more evidence.

Which goal is in the sweet spot without the tool? And with it?

Say it to your boss

Marina is talking to her boss. Circle the sentence that follows the pattern.

EXAMPLE Marina wants her boss to explain the priorities.
I would ask you to explain the priorities.
Family 1: ask + person + to + verb.

1 Marina proposes a number: 520.
- ○ I would propose us to set the goal at 520.
- ○ I would propose that we set the goal at 520.
- ○ I would propose that we sets the goal at 520.

2 Marina wants her boss to allow two weeks to learn the new tool.
- ○ Would you let me use two weeks to learn the new tool?
- ○ Would you let me using two weeks to learn the new tool?
- ○ Would you let me to use two weeks to learn the new tool?

3 Marina wants her boss to tell her if the tool changes the plan.
- ○ I would appreciate that you let me know if the tool changes the plan.
- ○ I would appreciate you to let me know if the tool changes the plan.
- ○ I would appreciate it if you could let me know if the tool changes the plan.

Too quiet, say this

Write a better version of each sentence on the line.

1 Sure, no problem.

_____

2 I will try my best.

_____

3 Whatever works for you.

_____

4 Sorry, I am a bit behind.

_____

5 Everything is fine.

_____

YOUR TURN · THE CASE

Choose a goal that you have now, at work or at school. Use the four sentences to talk to your boss, teacher or coach. Say it aloud in under a minute, and include one trade-off.

_____

_____

_____

9 NOW, AGAIN

Did the dossier move you?

Same six sentences. Look back at page 1. Did you move?

My boss usually explains why a goal matters.

○ Strongly disagree ○ Disagree ○ Not sure ○ Agree ○ Strongly agree

I would feel comfortable saying "this deadline is unrealistic."

○ Strongly disagree ○ Disagree ○ Not sure ○ Agree ○ Strongly agree

I work best when a goal makes me slightly uncomfortable.

○ Strongly disagree ○ Disagree ○ Not sure ○ Agree ○ Strongly agree

A measurable target motivates me more than "do your best."

○ Strongly disagree ○ Disagree ○ Not sure ○ Agree ○ Strongly agree

I tell my boss about a risk before it becomes a problem.

○ Strongly disagree ○ Disagree ○ Not sure ○ Agree ○ Strongly agree

I often keep my concerns to myself to avoid friction.

○ Strongly disagree ○ Disagree ○ Not sure ○ Agree ○ Strongly agree

Facts come from Gabarro and Kotter, Managing Your Boss, Harvard Business Review (1980), from Detert and Edmondson, Academy of Management Journal (2011), and from Google re:Work. For the Detert and Edmondson study, only the authors, the year and the main idea are given. The six fears, the sentences to say, the Marina numbers and the sample answers are written for this lesson. The comments and the people in the exercises are fictional.